interpretation of the border issue was historically correct, China was preparing for war.[20] For the Chinese, the legal approach to the border problem was ‘nothing but hypocrisy and fraud’,[21] Vertzberger argues. China saw no reason to honour what it terms ‘unequal, colonial treaties’ and therefore never recognized the McMahon Line. China still lays claim to most of today’s Arunachal Pradesh and continues to place the border along the foot of the mountains on all its official maps.

Those supporting China’s claims, among them Neville Maxwell and Alastair Lamb, point out that this is also approximately where maps from British times, and some even after India’s independence, show the border to be. Ironically, by referring to old maps and treaties, Maxwell and Lamb are making the same misjudgement as Nehru, but in reverse, with different interpretations. But not even the most ardent supporters of China’s claims would argue that the line on those old maps was an international boundary between India and China with border gates manned by Indian or British Indian, immigration and customs officials on one side and the Chinese on the other. Even if one assumes that Tibet was part of China when India was a British colony, it would also be hard to argue that the area was under Lhasa’s jurisdiction.

S. Mahmud Ali, former head of the Bengali language service of the British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC), states in his otherwise authoritative book about the Sino-Indian conflict that the NEFA, until 1951, had been ‘administered by Tibetan lamas’.[22] That is a gross misrepresentation of the reality at the time. No Tibetan lamas ever ruled over the area now claimed by China. Tibetan tax collectors were stationed at Tawang and a few other areas in the far west and taxes were also collected from some village tracts in the immediate vicinity of the crest of the Himalayan ranges, which was as far as centrally-controlled Tibetan administration ever reached. Today, China refers to Arunachal Pradesh as ‘South Tibet’, a concept that never existed in the past.

The line at the bottom of the hills on British maps simply marked the limits of organized colonial administration. The non-Tibetan tribes in the areas between that line and the McMahon Line for the most part governed themselves, but had commercial and other contacts with the Brahmaputra plain. If they spoke any language other than their own, it would have been